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Perceived Social Contribution: What Is It and How Can It Perpetuate Inequalities?

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ABSTRACT

Feeling as though one meaningfully contributes to society benefits physical health, psychological resilience, and political participation. Thus, any bias in what is perceived as a contribution has the potential to systematically disenfranchise people and exclude them from recognition and dignity. Extending past work showing that helping distant others (i.e., bridging help, e.g., volunteering) is perceived as contributing more to society than helping close others (i.e., bonding help, e.g., unpaid family caregiving), this paper examines how these disparities potentially function across individual, interpersonal, and institutional levels—from everyday conversations that are likely to praise volunteering over caregiving, to college admissions practices that favor formal public service, to legal systems that undervalue unpaid labor when calculating damages. Overall, a limited notion of what it means to contribute to society can maintain and perpetuate inequalities along the lines of social class, gender, and race and ethnicity in American society.

1 | Introduction

In U.S. American culture, choosing to help a stranger is perceived as more of a contribution to society than caring for an aging parent. This perception shapes not only how people view others but also who gets to feel valued as a contributing member of society, creating an implicit yet pervasive form of psychological inequality that can compound material disadvantage (Reinhart et al. 2024). The question of how one feels valued in society touches many aspects of life, including paid work, raising children, religion and spirituality, and civic engagement (Rossi 2001a). As one entry point into the broad questions of who is valued and how, I focus on perceived social contribution: how much people believe that whatever they do with their lives is valued by society and perceived as a worthy contribution to a larger collective (Keyes 1998). This perception is inherently subjective, informed by cultural ideas about what constitutes valuable labor that also have the power to privilege certain ways of being while disenfranchising others.

Drawing on established research and more recent investigations into how different forms of helping behaviors are culturally valued, this paper examines perceived social contribution both as a marker of social well-being and as a mechanism that can perpetuate social inequalities. Throughout, I raise questions about how a limited notion of what is perceived as a meaningful contribution to society may systematically disadvantage those who are marginalized by social class, gender, and race and ethnicity and operate across individual, interpersonal, and institutional levels. In doing so, I aim to extend past work on how social hierarchies perpetuate inequality (e.g., Marmot et al. 1999) by focusing specifically on how notions of who and what contributes to society can devalue individuals and lead people to believe that some lives matter more than others.

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2 | What Is Social Contribution?

With roots in classic sociological theory, Keyes' (1998) seminal paper on social well-being placed the notion of feeling as though one contributes to society in the psychological literature. Keyes argued that well-being was typically considered a feature of the private domain. Clinical traditions focused on identifying maladaptive behaviors and patterns of the private individual (e.g., Thoits 1992), whereas the psychological tradition focused on affect and beliefs within the individual (e.g., Diener 1984). Both traditions gave limited attention to the public sphere and how individuals are rooted in and shaped by their social environments and structures. Thus, the purpose of the social well-being dimensions was to incorporate the public nature of well-being by capturing how an individual feels in relation to their social environment. Keyes (1998) defines social well-being as "the appraisal of one's circumstance and functioning in society" (122) and identified various social challenges that adults face in their social lives. Specifically related to social contribution, Keyes draws on Marx's assertion that people are naturally productive and want to create and provide something for society (Israel 1971). Following this logic, feeling a sense that one contributes something of value to society meets this challenge of desiring to be a naturally productive person.

A concern with how individuals feel valued within society and why this matters spans multiple literatures (e.g., see Ridgeway 2019; Ridgeway and Markus 2022) and overlaps with but is distinct from several related constructs. Social contribution reflects a subjective *perception* (vs. more objective behaviors; Rossi 2001a, 2001b) of one's *current* (vs. generativity's future-oriented legacy-building and focus on the next generation; Erikson 1950) *value* (vs. social integration's emphasis on membership and belonging; Keyes 1998) to their *community and society* (vs. a sense of mattering's more interpersonal lens; Elliott et al. 2004; Flett 2022). In addition, several constructs measure various aspects of contributing, including contributing to the welfare and well-being of other people (Fleeson 2001; Kessler et al. 2004), expected contributions to others in the future (Grossman and Gruenewald 2020), the amount of control over and thought and effort put into one's contributions (Matsuba et al. 2007), as well as perceptions of how others evaluate their contribution to society (McAdams and de St Aubin 1992). Despite its relevance to many literatures and related constructs, the notion of how much one provides to society remains to be fully examined with many unanswered questions.

3 | What Are the Benefits of Social Contribution?

Feeling as though one contributes something meaningful to society has documented benefits for physical and societal health and well-being. Keyes' (1998) initial investigation found that perceived social contribution was positively related to but not overlapping with measures of global well-being and subjective physical health. Building on this work, Gruenewald et al. (2012) investigated whether perceptions of one's current contribution to others predicted health and mortality 10-years later among older adults. While past work had documented the desire to be socially useful and its health benefits (Gruenewald et al. 2009; Okun 1994), Gruenewald and colleagues were among the first to test these relationships longitudinally in a national sample. The authors analyzed data from older adults (aged 60–75) in the first two waves of the Midlife in the United States (MIDUS) dataset. In this sample, older adults who reported greater perceived social contribution at baseline were less likely to have increased disability status or to have died 10 years later while controlling for demographic, health, and psychosocial variables. Each one-point increase on a 0–10 current contributions scale was associated with 12% lower odds of dying (9% after full controls). Given that feeling as though one provides something of value to society has measurable effects on adults' health and longevity, the authors conclude that scientists and society alike should focus more on understanding the factors that maintain and strengthen a sense of being a productive and contributing member of society.

In addition to the effects on longevity, some more recent research by Nguyen et al. (2020) suggests feeling as though one contributes can foster psychological resilience when experiencing chronic pain. Chronic pain is one of the most common health conditions faced by midlife and older adults that also puts people at risk of isolation and reduced well-being (Reid et al. 2015). Because people who feel they contribute to society are more likely to engage in prosocial activities that foster social connections and reflect greater social capital (Almedom 2005; Weinstein and Ryan 2010), the researchers expected adults with chronic pain who reported relatively greater social contribution would perceive they have more social support and in turn experience greater well-being. Analyzing data from adults in the MIDUS Wave 1 and Wave 2 datasets who experienced chronic pain, the researchers found that how much chronic pain's interference with life impacted well-being depended on whether someone felt like they contributed to society. Among adults with relatively lower perceived social contribution, experiencing chronic pain interference reduced well-being. However, among adults with relatively greater perceived social contribution, chronic pain interference did not impact overall well-being. Additional analyses suggest the relationship between pain interference, well-being, and perceived social contribution was, in part, driven by perceived social support. Specifically, social contribution buffered against chronic pain's negative effects partly because people with greater perceived social contribution reported greater social support, which was positively related to well-being. The authors noted that their focus on strength-based concepts moves away from deficit-based orientations to examine factors, such as believing one makes a meaningful contribution to society, that are markers of individuals who are thriving despite experiencing chronic pain.

In addition to benefits to physical health, some recent research suggests strong feelings of social contribution are also related to societal health (Reinhart et al. 2025). In both the first wave of the MIDUS dataset and a sample collected in the weeks preceding the 2024 U.S. Presidential election, believing one is a contributing member of society was related to increased political participation. Specifically, those who reported greater perceptions of social contribution were more likely to intend to vote, participate in social activism, seek instead of avoid political information, and volunteer for and donate to political organizations. This pattern of findings suggests feeling like a valued, contributing member of society not only relates to individual

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health and well-being but also societal health via civic engagement. These findings suggest that any systematic disparities in who gets to feel they are valued contributors to society can have significant implications for physical and societal health.

4 | Who Feels Like They Contribute?

Across multiple investigations spanning several decades, perceived social contribution is not equally distributed across sociodemographic groups. Mostly notably, social class emerged as the most consistent predictor of perceived contribution. Americans with lower socioeconomic status (e.g., relatively less education) consistently reported a reduced sense that they contribute to society compared to their higher socioeconomic status counterparts (Keyes 1998; Keyes and Shapiro 2004; Reinhart et al. 2024). Recent research also found that the social class disparity extends beyond self-perceptions to include how people think others perceive their contributions to society (Reinhart et al. 2024). Further, the patterns by age suggest that perceived contribution follows a curvilinear trajectory throughout the life course, peaking in midlife before declining in older age (Fleeson 2001; Keyes and Shapiro 2004).

Other sociodemographic factors revealed fewer clear patterns. Gender differences were inconsistent across samples (Fleeson 2001; Keyes and Shapiro 2004), but some findings suggest the effect of gender may vary by socioeconomic status. Among people with higher socioeconomic status, women reported greater perceived social contribution than men, but there were no gender differences observed among adults with relatively lower socioeconomic status (Reinhart et al. 2024). Marital status also revealed mixed findings depending on whether the models control for other demographic variables (Keyes and Shapiro 2004). Further, it is important to note that race was most often not systematically investigated in prior works, likely because of the over-representativeness of White participants in these samples. Additional data collection and analyses are needed to better understand if perceived social contribution varies by race and ethnicity patterning or if it interacts with other demographic markers. It is also unclear what factors might contribute to disparities more broadly in a sense of feeling like a valued, contributing member of society and what, if anything, could be done address them.

5 | What Might Account for the Social Class Disparity in Perceived Social Contribution?

Given that the social class disparity in perceived contributions to society emerged as the most robust sociodemographic difference, recent work aimed to unpack what might contribute to this disparity (Reinhart et al. 2024). Because helping others is one way, among many, of contributing to society that can also vary with social class, researchers investigated what forms of help are perceived as a worthy contribution to society. They investigated *bridging help*, designated as time spent helping distant others and includes the 8.8 billion hours Americans spend volunteering each year (National Center for Charitable Statistics Project Team 2020). In contrast, *bonding help* was designated as time spent helping close others such as family members and includes the 53 million Americans who care for another adult, which is most often a relative (AARP and National Alliance for Caregiving 2020). Though bridging and bonding help come in many varieties and are practiced by people navigating various social classes, volunteering to help strangers tends to be more common among people with relatively more education and income (i.e., higher social class contexts; Musick and Wilson 2008; Wilson 2000). This pattern is likely due to several different reasons, including generally having greater access to resources (e.g., more free time, better health, etc.), being more likely to be asked to volunteer, knowing others who volunteer, and having fewer people in their immediate social networks who need additional help (Brady et al. 1999; Egerton and Mullan 2008; Son and Wilson 2012). In contrast, unpaid family caregiving tends to be more common among people with relatively less education and income (i.e., lower social class contexts; AARP and National Alliance for Caregiving 2020; Rossi 2001b) for many reasons, including generally being more likely to have more people in their immediate social networks who have unmet needs, less ability to outsource caregiving work, and greater norms of reciprocity (Adler et al. 1998; Bruhn and Rebach 2014; Carey and Markus 2017).

The researchers hypothesized that bridging help (i.e., helping distant others, such as volunteering to help strangers) would be considered more of a contribution to society than bonding help (i.e., helping close others, such as unpaid family caregiving). In many Western cultures, helping strangers is perceived as altruistic, in part, because this type of help is thought to reflect a selfless concern for another, a sentiment often promoted by religious parables such as the "Good Samaritan" (Carlson and Zaki 2018; Nagel 1970; Darley and Batson 1973; Cialdini et al. 1997; Neuberg et al. 1997). Bridging help aligns with mainstream U.S. American culture's individualistic values and independent conceptualizations of the self that emphasizes personal choice as a means of demonstrating one's motivation (Bellah et al. 1985; Markus and Kitayama 1991, 2003; Savani et al. 2008). The greater perception of choice in helping distant others may lead observers to believe that it is not situational forces but rather internal qualities that drive the behavior and thus attribute the behavior to altruistic attributes of the helper (Heider 1958; Jones and Davis 1965). In contrast, the researchers expected bonding help to be perceived as contributing less to society because it is less often perceived as reflecting choice and instead is perceived as obligatory as people respond to the needs of others and one's responsibility to them (Markus and Kitayama 1994; McManus et al. 2019). Because behavior that is perceived to be driven by situational pressures, norms, and expectations is often less highly regarded than behavior that is perceived to be motivated by relatively more internal circumstances, bonding help may be thought to reflect less about the helper's intention and character (Kelley and Michela 1980). Helping family members is sometimes even viewed as potentially selfish, because the helper may benefit from helping (Carlson and Zaki 2018; Dawkins 1976). Thus, the researchers expected bonding help to be perceived as contributing less to society than bridging help, because the motivations are perceived as less clear. Critically, the hypotheses were rooted in observing aspects of Western culture that emphasize individual autonomy, and the researchers assert that this pattern is not inevitable nor universal and likely is not apparent in many other cultures (Miller et al. 1990; Nisbett 2003; Shweder and LeVine 1984).

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Through two experiments and a correlational study among helpers themselves, the researchers found that people considered bridging help (e.g., volunteering to help strangers) as contributing more to society than bonding help (e.g., caregiving and helping family members). In one experiment, participants read about two people who engaged in the exact same type of help, such as visiting a retirement home. In this vignette, one person visited with their grandmother whereas the other person visited with a stranger. Participants, on average, rated the person who helped a stranger as contributing more to society, being more morally good, and having more of a choice to help than the person visiting their grandmother. Further analyses show that the perceived amount of choice to help partially explained why people thought bridging help contributed more to society than bonding help. Finally, leveraging three waves of the MIDUS dataset, the results showed that differences in rates of volunteering and unpaid family caregiving partially accounted for the social class disparity in perceived social contribution. That is, people in higher social class contexts were more likely to volunteer more and, unsurprisingly, volunteering was strongly linked to believing one contributes something of value to society. On the other hand, people in lower social class contexts were more likely to provide more unpaid family caregiving, but this type of labor was less related to perceived contribution. Together, this series of studies provided evidence for a notion of contributing to society that prioritizes people who already have more access to power and prestige and may leave out types of help that are valuable to society and are more likely to be performed by the majority of the population (the majority of the U.S. population does not have a 4-year college degree; U.S. Census Bureau, 2020). However, this initial investigation focused solely on the social class disparity in believing one contributes to society and raises many unanswered questions about how a limited notion of what is considered a worthy contribution can perpetuate inequality in multiple other ways.

6 | How Can a Limiting Notion of Contribution Perpetuate Inequality?

A limiting idea of what is considered a contribution can devalue many ways people do good for others which can maintain and perpetuate inequalities. Below, I employ a culture cycle framework to consider the implications of a limiting notion of contribution to unpack how it functions at various, interconnected levels of culture, specifically within *individuals* themselves, occurring in *interactions* between people, and within prominent *institutions* in society (Markus and Conner 2013; Markus and Kitayama 2010).

6.1 | Individuals

Narrow ideas of what is considered a worthy contribution can systematically undervalue labor performed by many Americans, particularly those marginalized by social class, gender, and race. The devaluation of bonding help can serve as another hidden consequence of belonging to a marginalized group that further maintains and perpetuates inequalities. Individuals who provide unpaid care for others—labor that economists value at 600 billion dollars if it were paid (Reinhard et al. 2023)—may be at risk of not feeling they are fully contributing to society. This perception may exclude them from the well-being and physical health benefits that accompany feeling like a valued member of society (Gruenewald et al. 2012; Keyes 1998). It is important to note that future research investigating associations between unpaid caregiving and well-being may need to disentangle whether any effects are due to feeling that labor on behalf of others is not valued as a contribution or driven by the many emotional, financial, and even physical challenges faced by caregivers (Adelman et al. 2014). Future work can also investigate the specific mechanisms underpinning how feelings of contribution (or a lack of such a perception) relate to health. Such work can complement prior work on how control over one's job or the amount of stress one faces day-to-day can serve as an avenue through which social disadvantage impacts physiological processes that erode health (Marmot 2005; Marmot et al. 1997).

In addition to the social class disparity that served as the primary motivation for prior investigations, data from the AARP and National Alliance for Caregiving 2020 shows that unpaid family caregiving disproportionately affects women and people of color. As expected, women were more likely to be unpaid family caregivers than men. Specifically, women make up roughly 50% of the American population but 61% of unpaid family caregivers. Women who are caregivers also typically provide care for more individuals than caregivers who are men. In terms of race and ethnicity, the report found that caregivers of color face a greater care burden, on average, than White caregivers. Specifically, caregivers of color often transition to their caregiving role at younger ages than White caregivers, and African American and Hispanic caregivers provide more hours of care, on average, than White caregivers. Thus, undervaluing unpaid family caregiving devalues the many Americans who perform this vital labor on behalf of others.

The gendered patterns in helping and perceived contribution raise multiple unanswered questions for future research. In addition to being more likely to engage in some forms of bonding help like unpaid family caregiving, women are also, on average, more likely to volunteer, a form of bridging help, than men (Bureau of Labor Statistics 2016). This pattern is related to a number of different reasons, including different social roles expectations and prosocial motivations (Einolf 2011; Taniguchi 2006). One might expect that many women's relatively greater involvement in some forms of bonding help would position them to believe they contribute less to society, as was the case with social class. Or one might expect that women's relatively greater involvement in multiple types of helping, especially in bridging help, would lead to greater perceptions of social contribution than men. As mentioned, prior investigations into gender disparities in perceived social contribution are mixed, with one finding suggesting that women reported higher perceived social contribution than men only in higher social class contexts (Reinhart et al. 2024). Further, research investigating the intersections of gender and race is particularly limited, despite women of color performing a disproportionate share of caregiving broadly and potentially facing greater risk of having their contributions systematically devalued (AARP and National Alliance for Caregiving 2020; Hengelaar et al. 2023).

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Future research can focus on understanding when and why certain labors done on behalf of others translate to feeling as though one contributes to society. It is possible that women's greater involvement, on average, in bridging help serves as a protective factor against the devaluation of any bonding labor. It is also possible and likely that U.S. culture's socialization and expectation of women as taking on more caretaking roles than men influence perceptions of societal contribution. Men often receive more praise for engaging in caretaking work than women, in part, because it is less expected of men to perform this type of labor (Deutsch and Saxon 1998). Thus, bonding help performed by women may be perceived as even less of a contribution to society than men engaging in similar labor because it is expected for women to fulfill this role. Additionally, better understanding how paid versus unpaid work relates to these perceptions may help inform the interactions between gender and social class. Future research could extend the well-known arguments about devaluing labor performed in roles traditionally held by women (Gilligan 1993) to better understand how women perceive and value their social contributions to others and their communities.

In terms of race and ethnicity, the U.S. has a long history of devaluing the contributions of Americans of color across numerous domains (e.g., Hofstra et al. 2020). A limited idea of what is a worthy contribution and the devaluation of bonding help and caregiving has the potential to perpetuate racial inequality as well. While undervaluing caregiving and bonding help also undervalues the many Americans of color doing this important work, it is unclear if this devaluation might lead to any racial disparities in perceived contributions to society. As previously mentioned, past investigations often lack diverse enough samples to systematically investigate differences in perceived contribution by race. However, past work on mental health has found support for a "Black-White mental health paradox" describing the phenomena that despite facing racial systemic inequality, prejudice, and discrimination, Black Americans, on average, exhibit similar or greater mental health and self-esteem than White Americans (Gray-Little and Hafdahl 2000; Twenge and Crocker 2002). Other work found that Black Americans' advantage in positive mental health outcomes only increases after accounting for perceived discrimination (Keyes 2009). Scholars attribute this paradox to various protective factors, such as religious involvement, positive ingroup identity, and greater generativity concern for future generations (Crocker and Major 1989; Keyes 2009). However, it is possible that many Black Americans may maintain strong beliefs about their own contributions and their communities value of them but still face devaluation of their efforts by the larger society.

A different pattern emerged for adults with other racial and ethnic backgrounds. Specifically, one meta-analysis found participants who were Asian, Native American or Indigenous, or Hispanic reported reduced self-esteem compared to White Americans (Twenge and Crocker 2002). Given the pattern of racial disparities in some forms of mental health, it is possible many people with various racial and ethnic backgrounds will have a reduced sense that their efforts on behalf of others are perceived as valuable. Specific analyses of different races and ethnicities are needed to understand how Americans with varying identities perceive their contributions to society. Future work could leverage some of the subsamples of MIDUS that intentionally recruited more participants of color and also collect more diverse samples to be adequately powered to investigate the role of race and ethnicity in perceived contributions.

6.2 | Interactions

A limiting narrative of what constitutes a meaningful contribution to society likely manifests and replicates through everyday interactions. Day-to-day conversation can reflect and perpetuate status differences between conversation partners (Ridgeway 2014; Santoro and Markus 2024). Therefore, it is possible that when people discuss volunteering or other forms of bridging help with others that such disclosures are met with praise and enthusiasm. If the idea of volunteering as a worthy contribution is pervasive, it is likely that conversations about this relatively valued type of help can foster social recognition and engagement. In contrast, when people discuss aspects of bonding help, such as caring for an elderly parent, these disclosures may be met with sympathy rather than praise (Zwar et al. 2021). Bonding help may evoke sympathy, in part, due to the recognition that unpaid caregiving often involves caring for a loved one who has a serious illness or disability and is often emotionally, financially, and physically taxing (AARP and National Alliance for Caregiving 2020). An aversion to acknowledging the realities of aging and mortality (Barber et al. 2024) combined with the knowledge that the U.S.' lack of a robust social safety net means caring for others is often not well supported and resourced (Barczyk and Kredler 2018) may raise feelings of shame and a desire to avoid facing the immense challenge of caring for another. Notably, many volunteering opportunities, such as helping to provide basic needs for others (e.g., volunteering at a foodbank), also involve facing human pain and suffering. However, there is typically a greater distance between the volunteer and the recipient, which may serve as a buffer against the full emotional weight that is often inherent in caregiving. As a result, conversations about caregiving may lead to lower engagement from one's conversation partner, given the emotional weight and discomfort that discussing caregiving can raise. While it is important to acknowledge the difficulty of caregiving and other forms of bonding help, celebrating the meaning-making and sense of pride that many caregivers feel could help recognize the contributions caregivers make and potentially foster conversations with greater engagement and deeper connections (AARP and National Alliance for Caregiving 2020).

Potentially different ways of communicating with others about bridging versus bonding help may create recursive effects with broader implications for social inequality. People whose help to others receives enthusiastic validation may develop greater confidence in their sense of contributing, while those whose efforts receive more sympathy, but less admiration, may internalize the message that their labor is meeting an important family obligation but not contributing to the larger whole (Reinhart et al. 2024; McManus et al. 2019; England 2005). Even helpers who recognize the value of their bonding help may be met with messages from the broader culture that subtly devalue their efforts in ways that could create frustration at the lack of recognition (Daniels 1987). At scale, these everyday conversations could reinforce the cultural idea that bridging help

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contributes more to society than bonding help, continuing to systematically advantage those whose circumstances allow them to help in ways that are most culturally valued.

6.3 | Institutions

In addition to potentially influencing everyday interactions, a limiting notion of what is considered a contribution to society is institutionalized within U.S. culture and can also perpetuate inequality through these means. There are many institutions that influence U.S. American culture's views on what is considered a worthy contribution to society and replicate and transmit those messages, including the influential cultural behemoths of religion and capitalism (e.g., Weber 2001). Here, I focus on two microlevel aspects of culture: college admissions and awarding damages in the legal system. Applying to colleges and universities serves as an instance in which an applicant's contributions are evaluated by an institution. Applicants are asked to explicitly state what they have contributed to their current schools and communities and, rather implicitly, make the case for what they have the potential to contribute in the future. In some recent work, researchers found that the vast majority of the top-ranked colleges and universities in the United States mention the importance of applicants' prior contributions and potential contributions in their admissions and recruitment materials (Reinhart 2025). Some schools have implemented a broad notion of what may count as a contribution, including one school that specifically states, "there are many ways to make the world better." Yet, relatively more public-facing contributions, such as school clubs, sports teams, and volunteering are likely more expected compared to detailing helping one's family by babysitting younger siblings or working an after-school job to help support the family (Calarco 2018; Park et al. 2025). Given a limited notion of contributing and how it might be represented in the college application process, it likely does not occur to many applicants and their families that forms of bonding help could be considered contributions worthy of including, especially if a school does not provide messages that these types of contributions are valued. As a result, the admission process may further privilege applicants whose circumstances best position them to have a record of doing good in ways that match limited cultural ideas of contributing (Park et al. 2025; Snellman et al. 2015).

While there have been some calls to reform the admissions process (e.g., making standardized testing optional; National Association for College Admission Counseling 2008), most attention paid to extracurriculars has acknowledged that students have differential access to these opportunities (e.g., Covay and Carbonaro 2010; Fuligni 2020; Reinhart 2025). In addition, reforms to the admission process could also value what many students are already doing for others as worthy contributions in their own right. To be certain, some schools are promoting a more inclusive narrative, including one school that included the following in their admission materials: "a student can gain a great deal from helping his or her family with babysitting or other household responsibilities...Such experiences are important "extracurricular" activities and can be detailed in the extracurricular section." Future research can investigate if these inclusive messages promote a more diverse set of applicants and if they have any impact on whether applicants anticipate a greater sense of belonging if they believe that they are valued for their contributions. In sum, reporting one's contributions when applying to top colleges and universities, which are often regarded as pathways of social mobility (Boliver and Wakeling 2016; Chetty et al. 2017), may serve as another instance in which contributions are relevant, institutionalized, and can perpetuate existing inequalities but possibly exemplify ways of expanding the narrative, too.

The civil legal system serves as another instance in which what is deemed a worthy contribution to society must be contended with and at times assigned a monetary value. When someone is found responsible for harming someone else, such as in personal injury cases, a judge, jury, or attorneys must negotiate how much compensation is merited to account for the loss. While the factors that go into these decisions are varied, one critical consideration is the person's economic output quantified in terms of lost wages, often with less attention on unpaid contributions. The process of determining compensation relies on statistical tables to predict earning potential that are often biased as they replicate gender and racial pay discrimination (Chamallas 2004; Dominioni 2017). This overall pattern is especially problematic because people who are marginalized, including women, people of color, and those navigating lower social class contexts, are also more likely to face discrimination in the process of assigning damages for a host of other reasons in addition to the inequality faced in estimating their worth (e.g., Chamallas 2004).

The process of assigning monetary value to someone's loss potentially institutionalizes social status with economic implications by defining the worth of a human life as primarily based on how much money they likely would have made. Further, the process of assigning lower value to certain types of labor potentially perpetuates the cultural narrative that this type of work is less important. This creates a cycle where legal institutions legitimize cultural hierarchies about valuable work, which then reinforces these hierarchies in the broader society and perpetuates social inequality (Bourdieu 1986; Ridgeway 2014; Ridgeway and Markus 2022).

7 | Conclusion

Given that a sense of contributing to society is important to individual functioning and relevant across a number of aspects of American life, any bias in what is perceived as a contribution has the potential to systematically disenfranchise people and exclude them from their full value and dignity. This disenfranchisement can occur based on social class, gender, and race and ethnicity, among other identities. It can occur in everyday conversations as well as in the institutions that gatekeep social mobility or are responsible for providing justice in response to being wronged. Valuing more and diverse forms of social good as worthy contributions has the potential to redistribute respect and recognition, honor the full spectrum of how Americans do good for their communities and society, and begin to address the inequalities that stem from our current narrow definitions.

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Conflicts of Interest

The author declares no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

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